

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 309

By Yager

A RESOLUTION to welcome Captain Barry "Butch" Wilmore and Captain Sunita "Suni" Williams back to Earth after completing their mission aboard the International Space Station.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly take great pleasure in recognizing two astronauts who served the disciplines of aeronautics and space flight with distinction and demonstrated their devotion to their country and their mission during their more than nine-month stay aboard the International Space Station (ISS); and

WHEREAS, after nearly 300 days in orbit, Captain Barry "Butch" Wilmore and Captain Sunita "Suni" Williams, the astronauts who flew on Boeing's Starliner for its first crewed mission, returned to Earth on March 18, 2025; and

WHEREAS, Captain Wilmore and Captain Williams arrived at the ISS in June 2024 for a scheduled short stay as part of the Starliner's test flight; however, technical issues prevented them from returning home on the spaceship; and

WHEREAS, NASA decided to keep them at the ISS for a few extra months to maintain staffing levels, later launching the SpaceX Crew-9 mission with only two astronauts, instead of the usual four, to provide Captain Wilmore and Captain Williams with a ride back home; and

WHEREAS, the average person would probably not relish spending more than nine months in space, but these two veterans of space flight enjoyed their extra time in the cosmos, modestly referring to their extended stay as "just part of the job"; and

WHEREAS, in the early morning of March 18, 2025, Captain Wilmore and Captain Williams boarded the SpaceX Dragon at the ISS to return to Earth; after a seventeen-hour voyage, the Dragon made a water landing off the Florida coast that evening; and

WHEREAS, a proud Tennessean, Captain Barry "Butch" Wilmore hails from Mt. Juliet and has earned degrees from Tennessee Technological University and the University of Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, selected as an astronaut by NASA in July 2000, Butch Wilmore is a retired U.S. Navy captain and a veteran of two spaceflights; he has accumulated more than 8,000 flight hours and 663 carrier landings; and

WHEREAS, Sunita Williams is also a retired U.S. Navy captain; selected by NASA as an astronaut in 1998, she has completed two space missions and logged over 3,000 flight hours in more than thirty different aircrafts; and

WHEREAS, Captain Wilmore and Captain Williams are to be greatly commended for their dedication to duty in the face of adversity; these two astronauts served an extended stay in space without complaint or compunction, and they are worthy of our approbation upon their return home; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we welcome Captain Barry "Butch" Wilmore and Captain Sunita "Sunni" Williams back to Earth after completing their extended nine-month mission aboard the International Space Station, thank them for their ongoing commitment to space exploration, and wish them all the best in their future endeavors.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.